INDIA@PARIS 2024

WIND IN HER SAILS

NETHRA KUMANAN, 26

Sport: ***SAILING***

Achievement: **Gold at the Asian Championships in 2022**

How she qualified: **Got a quota under the Emerging Nations Programme at Last Chance Regatta, an Olympic qualifier event**



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"Can you stop, please?" Nethra pleads with her father as he teases her about how she spends as much time on her phone as on sailing. It's May 2024 and Kumanan is home in Chennai—a rare occasion, since she has spent most of the past five years training in Spain. As we conduct the interview over Zoom, her father listens in on his daughter reflecting on her journey. Nethra talks of how a sports psychologist, provided by Dream Sports Foundation, has helped her navigate pressure. "Sailing is a mental sport," she says. "A lot of components are not under our control. It's still something I struggle with." Nethra's event in the Olympics is the women's Laser Radial, named after the single-sail, single-handed dinghy.

If Nethra's qualification for the Tokyo Olympics was a landmark event—she was the first Indian woman sailor to qualify—making the cut in Paris is morale-boosting too. "We were expecting to do it last year at the Asian Games," says Nethra. "I came really close, but underperformed when it counted."

The first thing to understand about sailing, Nethra tells us, is the scoring system: the one who scores the least, wins. "It's not about doing the best, but making the least mistakes as you go around the course," she says. "We don't race against forces of nature [wind, current] but against others. It's a lot of decision-making."

Sailing isn't that inaccessible a pursuit in India as many tend to think, reveals Nethra. She dabbled with tennis, badminton and basketball before discovering a love of sailing after a summer sailing camp. "It's unlike anything else," she says. "It is exhilarating being on the ocean, sometimes you get to see marine life. You learn the simple physics of it to get the extra metre of advantage." Though sailing has gained some traction in India with more sailing clubs and government support, an ocean worth of effort is still required. "To bridge the gap with European sailors, we have to train there," she says. In comparison to Tokyo, Nethra feels better prepared in Paris as she will have coach Tamas Eszes by her side as she negotiates the winds and tides of the Mediterranean at the Marseille Marina. Nethra and Vishnu Saravanan, India's two sailing athletes, are already prepping in Marseille. Says Nethra, "I know what to expect, what can throw me off. Now I can focus on what I have to do." ■

–Suhani Singh